

# *The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky*

Stephen Crane · 1898

First published: McClure's, Feb 1898

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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# Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

**Edition:** Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Bride_Comes_to_Yellow_Sky (revision 13850340), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

**Grades:** Grades 9–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

## Essential questions

- What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggest about the end of the Old West?
- What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggest about marriage and change?
- What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggest about comedy of expectation?

## Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

## Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

**Primary codes:** RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
**Assessments:** Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
**Differentiation:** Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
**Materials:** Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

## The 90-minute lesson

| # | Segment | Mode | Minutes | Clock |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Bell-ringer | You do | 8 | 0–8 |
| 2 | Vocabulary with etymology notes | I do | 10 | 8–18 |
| 3 | Background and context | I do | 10 | 18–28 |
| 4 | I do: modeled close reading | I do | 12 | 28–40 |
| 5 | We do: guided annotation | We do | 15 | 40–55 |
| 6 | You do: independent annotation | You do | 15 | 55–70 |
| 7 | Discussion | We do | 10 | 70–80 |
| 8 | Exit ticket / chapter quiz | You do | 7 | 80–87 |
| 9 | Closure | I do | 3 | 87–90 |
| | **Total** | | **90** | |

# Syllabus

| Week | Chapters | Lessons | Focus and activities | Assessment |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky | 1 × 90 min (90 min) | *the end of the Old West*<br>• Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure<br>• Story quizzes in the app<br>• Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week) | Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt |

# Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

# Lesson 1: The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky

**Focus:** the closing of the frontier

**Content note (gunplay, drunkenness):** Sensitive content: Gunplay; drunkenness. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
**Student preview:** Heads-up: this story includes gunplay; drunkenness.
**Suggested language:** "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Marshal Jack Potter rides a Pullman car home to Yellow Sky with his new bride, anxious because he married without telling the town. Meanwhile drunken Scratchy Wilson terrorizes the empty street with revolvers, looking for his old enemy Potter. Scratchy confronts the unarmed marshal, hears he is married, says 'I s'pose it's all off now,' and walks away.

**Background:** Published in 1898. The railroad and Eastern manners reached the Southwest as the 'frontier' was declared closed (1890 census).

**Significance:** A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat.

*Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)*

**0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
*Settle in and write for five minutes: How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes gunplay; drunkenness.*

**8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)**
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
*Today's words are dutifully, epithets, equanimity, narrowly, antagonist. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully." In this sentence it means: out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.*

**18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)**
Present the historical and literary background.
*Here is what the first readers of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky would have known. Published in 1898. The railroad and Eastern manners reached the Southwest as the 'frontier' was declared closed (1890 census). Why does this story matter? A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat. Write down one question you want answered.*

**28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)**
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
*Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "The bride was not pretty, nor was she very young." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to the closing of the frontier? I circle "dutifully", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.*

**40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)**
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
*Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.*

> *The bride was not pretty, nor was she very young. She wore a dress of blue cashmere, with small reservations of velvet here and there and with steel buttons abounding. She continually twisted her head to regard her puff sleeves, very stiff, straight, and high. They embarrassed her. It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully. The blushes caused by the careless scrutiny of some passengers as she had entered the car were strange to see upon this plain, under-class countenance, which was drawn in placid, almost emotionless lines.*

**55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)**
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
*Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Setting, Characterization: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky develops the idea of the closing of the frontier. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.*

**70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)**
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
*Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to the end of the Old West? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.*

**80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)**
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
*Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about the closing of the frontier, backed by one short quotation.*

**87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
*Today we saw how irony shapes the closing of the frontier. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.*

Total: 90 minutes.

### *Vocabulary with etymology notes*

| Word | Definition (in this sentence) | In context | Word history |
|---|---|---|---|
| **dutifully** (adverb) | out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner | *It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **epithets** (noun) | a defamatory or abusive word or phrase | *After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **equanimity** (noun) | steadiness of mind under stress | *Two rows of negro waiters, in glowing white suits, surveyed their entrance with the interest and also the equanimity of men who had been forewarned.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **narrowly** (adverb) | closely; carefully | *The traitor to the feelings of Yellow Sky narrowly watched the speeding landscape. "We're nearly there," he said.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **antagonist** (noun) | someone who offers opposition | *The name of Jack Potter, his ancient antagonist, entered his mind, and he concluded that it would be a glad thing if he should go to Potter's house and by bombardment induce him to come out and fight.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **patronage** (noun) | the act of providing approval and support | *The patronage, entwined with the ordinary deference, was not plain to them.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **exceeded** (verb) | be greater in scope or size than some standard | *It could only be exceeded by the burning of the new hotel.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **deference** (noun) | a courteous expression (by word or deed) of esteem or regard | *The patronage, entwined with the ordinary deference, was not plain to them.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **bridegroom** (noun) | a man who has recently been married | *The second weapon was aimed at the bridegroom's chest.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |
| **attracted** (verb) | direct toward itself or oneself by means of some | *Ultimately the man was attracted by the closed door of the "Weary Gentleman" saloon.* | Student look-up (not yet verified) |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | psychological power or physical attributes | | |

### *Discussion questions*

1. How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with the end of the Old West?

### *Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)*

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

**Literal / recall**

1. How is Potter traveling home? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In a Pullman train car
2. Why is Potter nervous? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He married without telling the town
3. What is Scratchy Wilson doing when the train arrives? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Drunkenly shooting up the town
4. Is Potter armed when he meets Scratchy? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: No, he has no gun
5. Why does Scratchy end the fight? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He learns Potter is married
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Marshal Jack Potter rides a Pullman car home to Yellow Sky with his new bride, anxious because he married without telling the town. Meanwhile drunken Scratchy Wilson terrorizes the empty street with revolvers, looking for his old enemy Potter. Scratchy confronts the unarmed marshal, hears he is married, says 'I s'pose it's all off now,' and walks away.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.” What does “dutifully” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: dutifully: out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner.

10. Reread: “After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.” What does “epithets” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: epithets: a defamatory or abusive word or phrase.

**Inferential / analytical**

1. What does “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky” suggest about the closing of the frontier? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about the closing of the frontier? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. In the passage that begins “The bride was not pretty, nor was she very young.”, why might Crane have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Marshal Jack Potter rides a Pullman car home to Yellow Sky with his new bride, anxious because he married without telling the town. Meanwhile drunken Scratchy Wilson terrorizes the empty street with revolvers, looking for his old enemy Potter. Scratchy confronts the unarmed marshal, hears he is…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky” set up that the rest of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How do big life changes, like marriage, change how others see us?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with the end of the Old West? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
10. Background: Published in 1898. The railroad and Eastern manners reached the Southwest as the 'frontier' was declared closed (1890 census). How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

**Evaluative / synthesis / creative**

1. A critic might argue: "A parody of the Western showdown; often taught with The Open Boat." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about the closing of the frontier? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to marriage and change: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Crane need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky" treats the closing of the frontier with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve the end of the Old West? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the closing of the frontier? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Stephen Crane about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

### *Annotation focus*

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

### *Chapter quiz*

1. How is Potter traveling home?

   A. By stagecoach

B. On horseback

C. In a Pullman train car

D. On foot

2. Why is Potter nervous?

A. He owes money

B. He is wanted by the law

C. He lost his badge

D. He married without telling the town

3. What is Scratchy Wilson doing when the train arrives?

A. Sleeping

B. Waiting to greet Potter

C. Drunkenly shooting up the town

D. Working in the saloon

4. Is Potter armed when he meets Scratchy?

A. No, he has no gun

B. Yes, with two pistols

C. He has a knife

D. Yes, with a rifle

5. Why does Scratchy end the fight?

A. Potter shoots him

B. The sheriff arrives

C. He learns Potter is married

D. He runs out of bullets

6. In the line "It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.", what does "dutifully" most nearly mean?

A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

B. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

C. steadiness of mind under stress

D. closely; carefully

7. In the line "After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.", what does "epithets" most nearly mean?

A. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner

B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase

C. steadiness of mind under stress

D. closely; carefully

**Answer key:** 1. C (In a Pullman train car); 2. D (He married without telling the town); 3. C (Drunkenly shooting up the town); 4. A (No, he has no gun); 5. C (He learns Potter is married); 6. B (out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner); 7. B (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase)

### *Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)*

**Middle School** (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky," how does Crane show the closing of the frontier? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

**HS Freshman** (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, how does Crane develop the idea of the closing of the frontier? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

**HS Sophomore** (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky develops the idea of the closing of the frontier. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of the closing of the frontier. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**HS Senior** (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky suggests about the closing of the frontier. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

**AP** (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Stephen Crane uses irony in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky to complicate the reader's understanding of the closing of the frontier. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

**College Freshman** (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of the closing of the frontier responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

**College Sophomore** (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of the closing of the frontier follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

**College Junior** (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky and its treatment of the closing of the frontier. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

**College Senior** (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky as evidence for a larger claim about the closing of the frontier in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

**Graduate / PhD** (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of the closing of the frontier. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky.

### *SAT-style questions*

1. *Two rows of negro waiters, in glowing white suits, surveyed their entrance with the interest and also the equanimity of men who had been forewarned.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “equanimity” most nearly mean?

   A. steadiness of mind under stress

   B. direct toward itself or oneself by means of some psychological power or physical attributes

   C. a courteous expression (by word or deed) of esteem or regard

   D. a man who has recently been married

2. *The bride was not pretty, nor was she very young. She wore a dress of blue cashmere, with small reservations of velvet here and there and with steel buttons abounding. She continually twisted her head to regard her puff sleeves, very stiff, straight, and high. They embarrassed her. It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully. The blushes caused by the careless scrutiny of some passengers as she had entered the car were strange to see upon this plain, under-class countenance, which was drawn in placid, almost emotionless lines.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky”?

   A. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

   B. The closing of the frontier

   C. A woman's brief taste of freedom

   D. A story so convincing it becomes real

**SAT key:** 1. A (steadiness of mind under stress); 2. B (The closing of the frontier)

# Whole-book test

**The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky: whole-book test** · 90 minutes

## Part I: Multiple choice

1. How is Potter traveling home?
   A. By stagecoach
   B. On horseback
   C. In a Pullman train car
   D. On foot
2. Why is Potter nervous?
   A. He owes money
   B. He is wanted by the law
   C. He lost his badge
   D. He married without telling the town
3. What is Scratchy Wilson doing when the train arrives?
   A. Sleeping
   B. Waiting to greet Potter
   C. Drunkenly shooting up the town
   D. Working in the saloon
4. Is Potter armed when he meets Scratchy?
   A. No, he has no gun
   B. Yes, with two pistols
   C. He has a knife
   D. Yes, with a rifle
5. Why does Scratchy end the fight?
   A. Potter shoots him
   B. The sheriff arrives
   C. He learns Potter is married
   D. He runs out of bullets
6. In the line “It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.”, what does “dutifully” most nearly mean?
   A. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   B. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner
   C. steadiness of mind under stress
   D. closely; carefully

7. In the line “After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.”, what does “epithets” most nearly mean?
   A. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner
   B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   C. steadiness of mind under stress
   D. closely; carefully
8. As used in the story (“It was quite apparent that she had cooked, and that she expected to cook, dutifully.”), what does “dutifully” mean?
   A. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner
   B. someone who offers opposition
   C. a courteous expression (by word or deed) of esteem or regard
   D. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
9. As used in the story (“After a decent wait, the man howled further challenges, mingling with them wonderful epithets.”), what does “epithets” mean?
   A. the act of providing approval and support
   B. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
   C. a man who has recently been married
   D. steadiness of mind under stress
10. As used in the story (“Two rows of negro waiters, in glowing white suits, surveyed their entrance with the interest and also the equanimity of men who had been for”), what does “equanimity” mean?
    A. be greater in scope or size than some standard
    B. direct toward itself or oneself by means of some psychological power or physical attributes
    C. steadiness of mind under stress
    D. closely; carefully
11. As used in the story (“The traitor to the feelings of Yellow Sky narrowly watched the speeding landscape. "We're nearly there," he said.”), what does “narrowly” mean?
    A. a courteous expression (by word or deed) of esteem or regard
    B. out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner
    C. someone who offers opposition
    D. closely; carefully
12. As used in the story (“The name of Jack Potter, his ancient antagonist, entered his mind, and he concluded that it would be a glad thing if he should go to Potter'”), what does “antagonist” mean?
    A. someone who offers opposition
    B. a man who has recently been married
    C. a defamatory or abusive word or phrase
    D. the act of providing approval and support

## Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how the end of the Old West develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how marriage and change develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how comedy of expectation develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

## Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (the end of the Old West, marriage and change, comedy of expectation) and argue how the ending reframes it.

## Answer key

**Answer key:** 1. C (In a Pullman train car); 2. D (He married without telling the town); 3. C (Drunkenly shooting up the town); 4. A (No, he has no gun); 5. C (He learns Potter is married); 6. B (out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner); 7. B (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase); 8. A (out of a sense of duty; in a dutiful manner); 9. B (a defamatory or abusive word or phrase); 10. C (steadiness of mind under stress); 11. D (closely; carefully); 12. A (someone who offers opposition)

# Essay assignments

## Essay: The end of the Old West

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky teaches about the end of the Old West. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops the end of the Old West across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the end of the Old West. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the end of the Old West, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky's treatment of the end of the Old West in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Name

your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the end of the Old West in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Marriage and change

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky teaches about marriage and change. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops marriage and change across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of marriage and change. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of marriage and change, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky's treatment of marriage and change in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on marriage and change in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

## Essay: Comedy of expectation

**Middle School** (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky teaches about comedy of expectation. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

**HS Freshman** (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Stephen Crane develops comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

**HS Sophomore** (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Stephen Crane develops comedy of expectation across The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

**HS Junior** (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of comedy of expectation. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

**HS Senior** (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

**AP** (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Stephen Crane's choices in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of comedy of expectation, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

**College Freshman** (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky's treatment of comedy of expectation in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

**College Sophomore** (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Junior** (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**College Senior** (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Graduate / PhD** (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on comedy of expectation in The Bride Comes to Yellow Sky, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

**Rubric:** Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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